undertake targeted killings of anti-India militants based in Pakistan. While there is no easy way to authenticate this aspect of India's covert actions, confidential assertions of the very existence of such programmes highlight how New Delhi may have engaged with Afghan diaspora settled in India. T, for instance, confirms that the R&AW was making 'efficient use' of the Afghan students in India for intelligence gathering purposes.[164] Though unaware of offensive covert operations undertaken by India as alleged by Pakistan, he does not reject all Pakistani allegations (even if he would temper down some such allegations).

Pakistan's uncontrolled spiral into violence elicited curious responses from Indian security officials. If the conciliators worried about the deteriorating situation, it was *schadenfreude* for the partisans. Similar to the early and mid-1990s' discourse of turning Afghanistan into Pakistan's Vietnam, the partisans viewed the TTP and its NDS links as an effective tool to bog down the Pakistan military. As Sahgal put it, 'the assessment we had was that Pakistan would require close to about 32 Brigades, which means about 10 Divisions plus for counter-insurgency operations. We were also trying to look at what kinds of operations were going on over there, which in turn created a void on the east [LoC]. So the perception was that if push came to shove, can we utilise that void for [strikes in Pakistan], because of post-Mumbai options?'[165] Indeed, on 15 June 2014, Pakistan launched Operation *Zarb-e-Azb* in North Waziristan.[166] While India never conducted any strikes against Pakistan after 26/11, its security planners had, quite unsurprisingly, thought of different possible scenarios of containing Pakistan's military and use that as a tool to set the terms of talks with Pakistan on Kashmir and other bilateral issues.[167]

As for Afghanistan, India was confident that it would not slip back to the 1990s where one (or more) Pakistan-supported group(s) would dominate in Afghanistan's political space. True, Afghanistan may not be safe, and often stable, but it will not be under Pakistan's influence either. If it were to happen that any specific Afghan Taliban faction began to dominate the battle then it 'should not be a Pashtun [versus] non-Pashtun front line. It should be Pashtuns fighting reactionary Pashtuns backed by radicalism and Pakistan with the support of the rest', says Mukhopadhaya.[168] By supporting Karzai, talking to his domestic opponents to accept his authority, cautiously opening channels with the Afghan